

Western intervention in the Muslim world heightened the belief among Islamists that the West was the enemy of Islam.

The Arab Spring

The 9/11 attacks were inspired by a radical ideology and belief that the fundamental problems plaguing Arab and Muslim people could be resolved by attacking foreign powers that were seen to oppress Islam. In 2011, young Arabs—looking inward to promote change and blaming their own leaders for decades of political, economic, and cultural decline—were at the heart of uprisings across the Arab world. At its core, what became known as the Arab Spring was a new generation's attempt to change the state order. An extraordinary series of pro-democracy uprisings, the Arab Spring caused huge upheavals in the Middle East and North Africa. It started in Tunisia on December 17, 2010, when a street vendor set himself on fire in a protest against police brutality. Protesters throughout Tunisia demanded democracy, and President Zine el Abidine fled the country on January 14. Disorder spread from Tunisia to Algeria, where there was unrest over lack of jobs.

On January 25, thousands of protesters took to the streets in Egypt, and after 18 days of protests there, President Hosni Mubarak resigned. By mid-February, civil unrest had swept through Bahrain, where it was brutally suppressed, and into Libya. Muammar Gaddafi's violent response to the dissidents led to civil war. An international coalition led by NATO launched a campaign

of air strikes targeting Gaddafi's forces, and he was killed in October 2011.

Further uprisings occurred in Jordan, Yemen, and Saudi Arabia, but the worst violence against civilians was seen in Syria, where President Bashar Assad promised reforms but used force to crush the dissent—a move that merely hardened the protesters' resolve. In July 2011, hundreds of thousands of people took to the streets, and the country descended into civil war. By August 2015, the United Nations reported that more than 210,000 people had been killed in the conflict. Capitalizing on the chaos in the region, so-called Islamic State (also referred to as IS, ISIS, or ISIL), the extremist Muslim group born from a fringe of al-Qaeda, took control of huge swathes of territory across northern and eastern Syria, as well as neighboring Iraq.

Middle East instability

The Suez Crisis was the end of one era in the politics of the Middle East and the start of another. It marked the humiliating end of imperial influence for two European countries, Britain and France, whose role was soon taken over by the US. It stimulated Arab nationalism and opened an era of Arab-Israeli wars and Palestinian terrorism.

In modern times, the Middle East has never seemed so unstable. Wars are being fought over religion, ethnicity, territory, politics, and commerce, and these conflicts have led to the worst refugee crisis since World War II, with millions fleeing anarchy and fanaticism. ■

Terrorism in the Middle East

Since the mid-20th century, terrorism has been synonymous with the Middle East. The Israel-Palestine conflict is one of the world's most challenging.

In 1964, Arab leaders formed the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO), declaring Israel's

establishment illegal. The PLO used terrorism to attack Israel and Western targets for their support of Israel. In 1970, Palestinian militants blew up three hijacked planes in the Jordanian desert, and in 1972 a group linked to the PLO hit the Israeli Olympic team during the games in Munich, Germany.

In 1983, Hezbollah, an Iran-backed fundamentalist

Shiite Muslim group in Lebanon, blew up the Beirut barracks of both US Marine and French forces, killing 298 people. Hezbollah pioneered the use of suicide bombers in the Middle East.

Both Jews and Muslims have employed terrorism to derail the many attempts that have been made at peace in the region.